

How To Tell

A lot of P2P users just claim ignorance of the legality of what they're downloading. Unfortunately, ignorance is not a plea that is going to do you any good in court. Here are a few tips to help you make sure that you're downloading safely.

- You're being offered a "free" download for something that's being sold online as well. You can find this by doing a Web search for the content you're downloading.

Verdict: Stop! Illegal content detected...

- You visit a site that is offering content you like, but instead of charging you per item of content (song, album, movie, software, etc.), you're being asked to pay a membership fee that entitles you to unlimited downloading of *anything*.

Verdict: Ahoy! Piracy ahead!

- The content you are downloading comes with a description of a "Creative Commons" license or has the words "Open Source" in its license agreement.

Verdict: Download away. Enjoy your legal content.

- While browsing for trailers of a new movie, or details about a song, you find a site that's giving the movie/music away for free. The filename also has one of these words in them: cam, DVD-rip, Stolen, warez, Telesync, Telecine, rip/ripped, MP3, etc.

Verdict: Skip past Go, don't collect \$200 and go directly to jail!

- You find that software that does exactly what you were looking for, but the download details include .nfo or .txt files with ominous sounding names. There might also be a file called "serial", "keygen" or "crack". Or perhaps the site you are going to download the file/Torrent from contains such words, or advertisements from pornographic sites. Further searching also reveals that the software manufacturer is only offering a time/feature limited trial version, and the license costs money...

Verdict: Welcome to the world of piracy. Download this and your dreams of becoming a criminal will be fulfilled.

You're all sheep! All being herded into nice little groups, and sheared... instead of wool, you're being shaved of your hard earned money. Thanks to big budget music videos, billions of dollars of marketing campaigns and paid-for airing of a particular type of music, you're being forced to buy/listen to music that is manufactured. This music is tailor-made to attract you; you're brainwashed into listening to it and, for the lack of anything better, liking it as well. How? All the music you hear comes from a few major recording labels, so few that you can count them on your fingers. The latest heart-throb is just a cute face that some recording label suit liked, made popular by a song that was written, composed and, in some cases, even performed by unknown, talented artistes. The genre, the rhythm, is all based on the statistical feedback of market surveys, and everything is basically just manufactured!

Extreme? Sure, but hardly unbelievable... Here are a few excerpts from www.downhill-battle.org, a non-profit organisation that aims

to let us sheep decide how to spend our wool, and why they think the world needs to be rid of the monopoly that major labels have on music!

"The major labels' business model requires them to have a steady stream of consistent products. The very nature of their operation produces homogenised music designed for specific radio formats and scientifically honed to hit-making models. Artists are signed and promoted based on the opinions of individual A&R executives, not the popularity of the music. When the major labels crumble, the diversity of mainstream music will blossom. It will be a revolution in pop culture. People will decide what's popular, not marketing.

"For decades, the major labels have controlled what's on the radio by paying radio stations to play their songs. Pay-for-play radio (aka "payola") means that independent labels can't get their music on mainstream radio and mediocre major label music gets on the radio just because somebody's paying.

"For artists on major labels, label bureaucrats hijack the sound and control the final product. The label picks the producer of the album and they can always refuse to release it; sometimes labels even trash entire albums. And at the end of the day the label—not the musician—owns the copyright to each song.

"The major label system is the biggest barrier to musicians making money off CDs. Major label artists only start getting their tiny share of royalties (5-10%) once they've sold over 500,000 units. Independent musicians can get a bigger cut, but thanks to major label payola they can't get on the radio and won't reach a large audience."

Now you can choose to think of all this as sour grapes, or a very nice eye-opener, and the choice is purely yours. However, you're probably wondering what all this big brotherly talk is doing in an article about P2P... well... you should visit http://www.eff.org/share/collective_license.php for an interesting idea on how P2P can help revolutionise the way we get our music.

In short, the Electronic Frontier Foundation (EFF) says that instead of suing a few Americans for downloading music, perhaps we should just charge every individual with a broadband con-

Downhill Battle MUSIC ACTIVISM

Downhill Battle is a non-profit organization working to support participatory culture and build a fairer music industry. [Learn More.](#)

To get project announcements, enter your email:

CURRENT AND UPCOMING

- DON'T BUY MAJOR LABEL MUSIC**
The Reasons
- M.I.A. Interview**
Independent Internet TV Platform.
- Fort Culture: taking sides.**
- Amazing DJ 2-Trip Interview**

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FLYER IN YOUR CITY
Help build our activist presence. Download flyers and hit streets and concerts in your area.

STICKER CDS
The major labels and the RIAA know they'll be revealed on the internet. They didn't know we'd take the fight into record stores. [See the photos and get stickers.](#)

TELL 20,000 PEOPLE
Most people don't know what to think about music sharing. Write a letter to the editor.

Downhill Battle T-Shirts
Check out our t-shirts, stickers, buttons and controversial CD labels. [Go to the store >>](#)

FLYER at Concerts

Vladimir Putin: Stop Snitching
NICHOLAS, DECEMBER 17 4:44PM
Here's a totally unrelated side-project that I whipped up over the weekend.

www.downhillbattle.org, ever the P2P-ers' ally in the fight for freedom